famous as Sanchi or Ajanta as one of India’s very few well-preserved early Buddhist sites.

In 1989 four of Emperor Ashoka’s major edicts were found carved on a stone slab on the floor of a collapsed Kali temple in a little village called Sannati on a bend of the Bhima River, which is an upper tributary of the Krishna. Five years later, as plans were being drawn up to build a dam upstream of Sannati, archaeologists carried out a wider survey of the immediate area and uncovered the remains of a massive stupa and attendant monastery near the village of Kanaganahalli. What makes this discovery so important is that even though the stupa itself had collapsed at some point in the distant past, shattering many of the large sculpted limestone slabs lining the body of the stupa, the site had never been plundered for building material. These slabs are little short of sensational as art works, and a magnificent addition to India’s limited portfolio of early sculpture. Many illustrate the Jataka tales and the life of the Buddha – shown in aniconic form as appropriate to this early stage of Buddhist art – very much as found at Bharhut, Amaravati and Sanchi.

The added bonus is that Kanaganahalli comes with a portrait gallery of eminent rulers from the Satavahana dynasty, all identified and presented in idealised form (see below and at the start of the chapter). They include Rajas Simuka Satakarni, Sri Pulumavi (either Pulumavi I, but more probably Shiva Sri Pulumavi) and Yajna Sri Satakarni (c. 152–181 CE), as well as a number of Buddhist heroes of whom the most striking is Emperor Ashoka, shown in the company of his queen and female attendants, and named in Prakrit and Brahmi in a brief inscription in the top left corner of the panel as *rayo asoko*, Raja Ashoka.